believed that the Soviet Union was a “moderating influence” in Southeast Asia and was trying to “offset” Chinese influence.[184]

Furthermore, Indian policymakers believed that greater US involvement in Vietnam would push the Soviet Union to come down on the side of China. This worried Indian officials, who were constantly concerned about the prospect of a Sino-Soviet rapprochement. Such a reconciliation would significantly change the balance in Asia and would undercut the very basis of India’s strategic approach by making the country more heavily dependent on the US. Finally, Indian policymakers believed that the American approach in Vietnam was counterproductive.

India’s concern translated into criticism of the US in forums like the International Control Commission, but what grated more in Washington was public censure. In June 1965, Indira Gandhi, then a minister, spoke out against American intervention—more forcefully than Shastri. She was mainly trying to burnish her credentials and strengthen her position vis-à-vis the prime minister, but many in the Indian government shared her assessment that escalated American involvement invited more Chinese intervention in Southeast Asia. Most Indian concern and criticism, however, were expressed privately. Shastri’s public appeals for negotiations, as Lawrence has noted, were “relatively balanced.” Furthermore, a number of “Indian officials continued to give Washington quiet support” through 1965.[185]

Rusk found the Indian attitude on Vietnam to be “generally helpful,”[186] but as Bowles noted in April 1965, India’s “failure publicly to recognize that we are in fact fighting their battles” was problematic from the administration’s perspective.[187] Johnson was particularly annoyed that, while Washington was holding the line for the free world, countries like India, threatened by communists, did not appreciate American efforts. After Shastri called for a ceasefire in Vietnam,[188] the president wrote to him that, “to us, the Chinese Communist-supported aggression in Vietnam poses the same kind of threat to Free World interests as Communist China’s attack on India in 1962.”[189] Komer agreed with him, asserting that India needed “to recognize that we’re fighting their war in Vietnam.”[190]

Assets and Liabilities